

From Gender Antagonism to Inclusive Solidarity? Trade Union Membership and Attitudes toward Women's Employment

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Abstract

Why and to what extent do union members hold different attitudes toward women's employment compared to non-members? Drawing on insights from multiple disciplines, I propose that a masculinized conception of work—viewing work as primarily for men—has historically underpinned gender antagonism in trade unionism. While many union leaders have increasingly supported gender equality, the rise of right-wing populism may have hindered the progress among many union members. This theorizing motivates an empirical analysis using four waves of the European Value Study data, covering 39,877 individuals in 14 Western European countries from 1990 to 2020. Pooling across waves, I find that union members show more egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment when compared to non-members with similar demographic and socio-economic backgrounds in the same country, on average. This relationship is further moderated by both individual and institutional characteristics, including skill levels, occupational gender composition, centralization of collective bargaining, and union density. Finally, I document a post-financial crisis shift in which the positive association between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment has attenuated or even reversed, particularly in countries where right-wing populism is more influential.

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1.Introduction

The labor movement has a long and complicated history with the struggle for gender equality, marked by both conflict and collaboration. Research on gender and organized labor shows that early trade unionism was often characterized by gender antagonism, as unions prioritized men's interests while marginalizing or excluding women and their concerns (Baker and Robeson, 1981; Fraser & Gordon, 1994; Lurie, 2018; Milkman, 2016; Rose, 1986, 1988). In recent decades, however, trade union leaders have increasingly sought to advance gender equality by recruiting women, incorporating gender equity into bargaining agendas, and promoting female-friendly workplaces (e.g., Berik & Bilginsoy, 2000; Bruno et al., 2021; Budd & Mumford, 2003, 2004; Elvira & Saporta, 2001; Gregory & Milner, 2009; Park et al., 2019). These developments reflect unions' broader efforts to build a more inclusive form of solidarity, one that actively recognizes the interests of historically marginalized groups as integral to workers' collective interests. Whether these organizational efforts are accompanied by similarly inclusive attitudes among rank-and-file members, however, remains largely unknown. Without a supportive membership base, unions may face important internal constraints in building inclusive solidarity and advancing gender equality, even when their leaders are formally committed to inclusion.

Against this background, the present study investigates why and to what extent union members' attitudes toward women's employment—an important aspect of gender equality—may differ from those of non-members. To explain why such differences may arise, I begin by examining gender antagonism in early trade unionism. I show that early unions often justified women's exclusion from employment based on a masculinized conception of work—one that viewed employment as primarily for men. This conception was grounded in two prevailing gender norms. The first, the ideal worker norm, prioritizes unwavering commitment to work and aligned

with craft unionism's emphasis on skill development (Acker, 1990; Milkman, 2016; Williams, 2000). The second, the breadwinner norm, positions men as primary earners and women as non-working wives—a belief popularized by early trade unionists through the family wage movement (Rose, 1986, 1988; Fraser & Gordon, 1994; Lurie, 2018; Montanari, 2000). Drawing on organizational imprinting theory (Stinchcombe, 1965; Marquis & Tilcsik, 2013), I argue that once embedded in unions' practices and cultures, these norms can continue to shape union members' gender attitudes even after the conditions that produced them have changed (Aleks et al., 2021; Ledwith, 2012; Lurie, 2014; Saari, 2013).

Trade unions, however, have not stood still. Social and economic developments over the past several decades have led many union leaders to actively promote gender equality. These organizational efforts may be associated with more egalitarian attitudes among union members through two distinct channels: a causal influence channel and a self-selection channel. Under the causal influence channel, union membership may directly shape workers' gender attitudes. Through repeated exposure to union leaders' messages and bargaining priorities, as well as participation in union governance and activities, union members may be socialized into more egalitarian views toward women's employment. By contrast, under the self-selection channel, unions that actively advocate gender equity may attract and retain workers with egalitarian gender attitudes (Schneider, 1987). Although the mechanisms differ, both channels imply the same prediction that union membership will be positively associated with egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment.

While these developments provide reasons to expect a positive association, they do not suggest that unions' progress toward inclusive solidarity is uniform or irreversible. In the study, I further argue that the growing influence of right-wing populism—a political movement combining

anti-elitism, nationalism, and authoritarianism—may have hindered unions’ effort to promote gender equality among their members. Rising amid austerity measures and cultural shifts, right-wing populism often mobilizes economic insecurity and promotes conservative social values, potentially sidelining gender equality as a collective priority and fueling backlash against gender-equality efforts among union members (Briskin, 2014).

Empirically, I analyze the relationship between union membership and attitudes toward women’s employment using four waves of the European Values Study, covering about 40,000 individuals in 14 European countries between 1990 and 2020. My primary goal is to assess whether union members hold more egalitarian attitudes toward women’s employment than non-members on average. Importantly, evidence of such a difference may suggest broad alignment between union members’ gender attitudes and unions’ organizational efforts to promote gender equality. Guided by the theoretical discussion of the masculinized conception of work and union leaders’ contemporary efforts to promote gender equality, I further conduct heterogeneity analyses to examine how the relationship between union membership and attitudes toward women’s employment varies across individual characteristics and institutional contexts, including skill levels, occupational gender composition, centralization of collective bargaining, and union density. Finally, I investigate how the relationship between union membership and attitudes toward women’s employment has changed over time and whether these temporal changes are related to the influence of right-wing populism.

This study seeks to make three contributions to industrial relations (IR) scholarship. First, the study advances understanding of the tension between trade unions’ historical gender antagonism and their contemporary pursuit of inclusive solidarity. Early trade unionists often built their organizational strategies and collective identities around gendered social norms, contributing

to a masculinized conception of work that privileged men's employment. Although many union leaders now seek to expand women's representation and incorporate their interests into union agendas, organized labor's gendered legacies may continue to shape the attitudes of union members. By examining whether union leaders' efforts to promote gender equality are accompanied by supportive attitudes of their members, the study conceptualizes inclusive solidarity not as an automatic outcome of union leaders' formal commitment to gender equality, but as an ongoing and potentially reversible process that requires continued effort to cultivate a supportive membership base. In doing so, the study also adds to the broader literature on the gendered nature of work (Acker, 1990; Ashcraft, 2013; Kelly et al., 2010; Milkman, 2016; Müller & Chung, 2025; Williams, 2000) and responds to recent calls to incorporate social identity more explicitly into IR scholarship (Hebson & Rubery, 2018; Lee & Tapia, 2021).

Second, on a more practical level, the study compares union members' attitudes toward women's employment with those of non-members, providing union leaders with a useful benchmark to assess their members' attitudinal foundations for inclusive solidarity. This perspective complements the broader literature on how unions can promote gender equality and create more female-friendly workplaces (e.g., Aleks et al., 2021; Barnacle et al., 1994; Berik & Bilginsoy, 2000; Bruno et al., 2021; Budd & Mumford, 2003, 2004; Elvira & Saporta, 2001; Greene & Kirton, 2002; Gregory & Milner, 2009; Ledwith, 2012; Lurie, 2014; Park et al., 2019; Saari, 2013). The heterogeneity analyses further show that the relationship between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment varies across individual characteristics and institutional contexts, suggesting that union leaders may want to tailor their gender equality initiatives to differences among members and across institutional settings.

Third and finally, the study identifies the rise of right-wing populism as an important contemporary challenge to gender equality (Cullen, 2021; Fraser, 2017; Korolczuk & Graff, 2018) and highlights union members' potential susceptibility to right-wing populist messages that leverage economic insecurity and anxieties induced by cultural changes. In doing so, the study suggests that the project of inclusive solidarity is not a settled achievement but an ongoing contest, vulnerable to reversal under adverse economic and political conditions. As such, progressive union leaders may want to pay closer attention to shifts in the economic and political landscape and explicitly incorporate gender equality in their responses to the right-wing populist challenge.

2. Trade Unionism and Attitudes toward Women's Employment

2.1 Gender Antagonism in Trade Unionism

Organizational theory holds that organizational collectives (e.g., industries, communities, and other groups with shared goals) tend to bear lasting imprints of the institutional conditions and cultural norms prevailing during their formative years (Stinchcombe, 1965; Marquis & Tilcsik, 2013). These imprints often become embedded in organizational practices, governance structures, and collective identities. They are then transmitted to later generations of members through processes of organizational socialization and participation. Applied to trade unionism, this perspective suggests that if certain gender norms became constitutive of organized labor during their early years, they may continue to shape contemporary union members attitudes toward women's employment. Examining the relationship between union membership and attitudes toward women's employment therefore would benefit from understanding gender norms underpinning early trade unionism.

Historians suggest that early trade unionism was frequently characterized by strong gender antagonism, as organized labor—mostly male—adopted various exclusionary strategies to restrict women’s employment at times. Rose (1988) presents a vivid example of such animosity in Kidderminster, England in 1874:

When they [employers] put women to work on the new looms, the male weavers . . . went on strike and were supported by all of the male carpet weavers in Kidderminster. The strike lasted only one week and resulted in victory for the union; the women lost their jobs and carpet weaving in Kidderminster remained men's work. (p. 199)

In addition to excluding women from the workplace, trade unionists engaged in the "gendering of machinery," designating certain machines for use exclusively by men or women (Rose, 1986). In practice, men frequently monopolized access to technologically advanced machines, while women were confined to operating machines associated with unskilled and exploitative work (Honeyman & Goodman, 1991).

Trade unionists’ hostility toward women’s employment has drawn much scholarly attention, in part because a purely economic account—women as cheap labor undercutting men's wages—cannot fully explain it. As Rose (1988) observes, early trade unionists also recruited other low-cost labor, such as rural workers, into their ranks. This suggests that it was women's employment specifically, rather than cheap labor in general, that provoked strong resentment among trade unionists. Baker and Robeson (1981, p. 24) sharpen the puzzle: “The interesting question is why men did not quickly include women in their unions and insist that women be paid the same wages as men, thus eliminating the threat.” To better understand this gender antagonism, scholars have tried to answer this puzzle by developing accounts that highlight the importance of two social norms—the ideal worker norm and the breadwinner norm. Crucially, both norms have historically

interacted with early trade unionism to reinforce a masculinized conception of work that views employment as primarily for men.

Specifically, the first account centers on the notion that work is not gender neutral but organized around the so-called ideal worker norm—one that expects workers to devote complete commitment to paid work while subordinating family responsibilities (Acker, 1990; Kelly et al., 2010; Müller & Chung, 2025; Williams, 2000). Importantly, the ideal worker is implicitly imagined as a man, since men have historically borne fewer family responsibilities and can therefore conform more readily to these expectations. While the ideal worker norm has broadly disadvantaged women in the labor market, it resonates particularly strongly with the philosophy of craft unionism that views skill as the defining basis of work (Milkman, 2016). Because many early trade unionists were craftsmen, they regarded skill as central to their identity and valued rigorous training and continuous practice. Since women were expected to shoulder greater family responsibilities and withdraw from work upon marriage, members of craft unions often perceived them as lacking the long-term commitment to acquire and develop their skill. Consequently, craft unionism institutionalized the ideal worker norm through its emphasis on work devotion and skill development. The exclusion of women from employment by early trade unionists was thus justified on the ground that women would degrade skilled work and undermine occupational standards.

The second account instead emphasizes the importance of the breadwinner norm, which posits that manhood is realized primarily through wage labor. Early trade unionists in many Western countries frequently invoked this breadwinner norm to advance their material interests (Lurie, 2018). As Fraser and Gordon (1994) write, nineteenth-century working-class men increasingly sought economic independence after winning their political rights. Yet rather than

seeking control over the means of production, working-class men pursued a new form of economic independence by rejecting “wage slavery” and demanding a family wage—“a wage sufficient for a male head to maintain a household and to support a dependent wife and children” (Fraser & Gordon, 1994, p. 316). Crucially, the family wage presupposed women’s confinement to the domestic sphere. As the family wage gained increasing significance within the labor movement, women were gradually seen as non-workers, while manhood was redefined as being the sole provider for one’s family (Fraser, 1994). The presence of women at work was thus doubly unsettling for men: Women not only competed for jobs and depressed wages but also undermined men’s ability to fulfill their breadwinner role (Rose, 1988). According to this account, early trade unionists actively incorporated the breadwinner norm into their bargaining demands and political agendas. the expectation that paid employment was primarily for men was thus institutionalized within trade unionism, justifying women’s employment from work.

From the organizational imprinting perspective, the significance of the ideal worker and breadwinner norms can extend beyond the historical contexts in which they emerged. Once embedded in unions’ bargaining practices, governance structures, and cultures, such norms may persist even after the broader social environment changes. Consequently, contemporary union members may continue to be exposed to assumptions about gender and work that originated during organized labor’s formative years. Some evidence suggests that elements of both gender norms remain visible in modern unions. Consistent with the breadwinner norm, Lurie (2014) finds that some Israeli unions negotiate wage premiums for fathers while offering flexible working arrangements to mothers. Crocker and Clawson (2012) similarly show that collective bargaining agreements for firefighters in the U.S. prioritize men’s breadwinner role while paying limited attention to caregiving responsibilities. Likewise, consistent with the ideal worker norm, Ness

(2012) attributes the persistent underrepresentation of women in the UK building trades partly to craftsmen's continuing emphasis on occupational skill identities and long working hours.

Gendered organizational legacies are also evident within unions' internal governance. Aleks et al. (2021) report that female union officers receive lower compensation than their male counterparts in the U.S. In addition, Kirton (2006) and Cooper (2012) document women's persistent underrepresentation in union leadership in the UK and Australia, respectively, partly due to a masculinist culture. Taken together, these findings support Kirton's (2006) and Ledwith's (2012) contention that a strong norm of masculinity is still found in many unions' structures, practices, and cultures. To the extent that union members are exposed to these institutions and norms through everyday union life, they may internalize those underlying gendered assumptions about work. In such cases, union members may be expected to hold less egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment than non-members who are less exposed to the gender norms embedded in union practices and cultures.

2.2 Toward Gender-Inclusive Solidarity?

While early trade unionism was often characterized by strong gender antagonism, unions in many countries have increasingly embraced gender equality as an explicit organizational goal over the past several decades. This transformation reflects unions' adaptation to changing economic, social, and political environments. One of the most important developments has been the dramatic rise in women's labor force participation, driven by expanded educational opportunities, advances in household and workplace technologies, and major historical events such as World War II (Cavalcanti & Tavares, 2008; Goldin, 1991, 2006; Goldin & Katz, 2002). As women have come to represent an increasingly large share of the workforce, unions have faced growing incentives to

recruit female members, address their workplace concerns, and incorporate gender equality into their bargaining agendas. Consequently, many unions have moved beyond their historically exclusionary traditions by promoting women's representation and advocating policies aimed at improving women's position in the labor market (Williamson & Baird, 2014).

This demographic shift has also created new opportunities for union revitalization. As manufacturing—the traditional stronghold of organized labor—has continued to decline across many developed countries, unions have increasingly turned to historically underrepresented groups, particularly women employed in the expanding service sector, as an important source of membership growth (Ibsen & Tapia, 2017). Yet unions' history of gender exclusion and masculinist culture has at times limited the effectiveness of these recruitment efforts (Baker & Robeson, 1981). This challenge, in turn, has prompted many union leaders to acknowledge the need for organized labor to confront gender inequality more openly and directly (Ledwith, 2012). Such recognition has led many unions to reframe collective bargaining not merely as a mechanism for complying with anti-discrimination legislation but also as a proactive instrument for advancing gender equality in the workplace (Dickens, 2000).

Additionally, public policy has reinforced unions' internal changes by positioning them primarily as complements to, rather than substitutes for, statutory efforts to promote gender equality (Deakin et al., 2015; Lurie, 2005). In France, for example, equality bargaining between employers and unions has been mandatory since 2006, providing unions with a formal mechanism to promote gender equality in the workplace (Bruno et al., 2021; Gregory & Milner, 2009). In the UK, where the enforcement of equality legislation relies less on a general labor inspectorate, unions have played an important role in translating statutory and case law on gender equality through collective bargaining with employers (Colling & Dickens, 2001). In New Zealand, unions

have likewise built on public initiatives promoting pay equity by incorporating gender equality clauses into collective bargaining agreements, further strengthening their role in advancing workplace gender equality (Pennington & Wenlock, 2021).

A substantial body of research has therefore documented what unions do, at the organizational level, to promote gender equality—through recruitment strategies, bargaining agendas, and engagement with public policy. However, far less is known about individual union members' own attitudes toward women's employment. Yet given unions' active efforts to promote gender equality, union members might be expected to hold more egalitarian attitudes than non-members, and two distinct mechanisms could account for such a pattern. First, unions may exert a causal influence on union members' gender attitudes through organizational socialization. As union leaders increasingly prioritize gender equality in collective bargaining, internal governance, and public communication, union members are repeatedly exposed to egalitarian norms, leading to a higher level of support for women's employment than non-members.

Second, consistent with the attraction-selection-attrition framework (Schneider, 1987), unions that increasingly embrace gender equality may attract and retain workers whose gender attitudes already align with their egalitarian agendas, while workers holding more traditional views may be less likely to join or remain members of such unions. Under this mechanism, union members would still exhibit greater support for women's employment than comparable non-members, even if union membership itself may not necessarily alter individuals' attitudes.

These two mechanisms are important to distinguish because they imply different theoretical explanations for the potential positive association between union membership and attitudes toward women's employment. They are also practically important to distinguish, as they suggest different pathways through which unions may promote gender equality. The first

mechanism highlights the agency of union leaders: By prioritizing gender equality in collective bargaining, organizational governance, and public communication, union leaders can actively shape members' attitudes through socialization and participation. Instead, the second mechanism highlights unions' capacity for self-reinforcement: As unions become more visibly gender-inclusive, they may increasingly attract and retain workers who already share their egalitarian outlook, thereby strengthening unions' gender equality initiatives over time. In practice, both mechanisms may operate simultaneously. Without innovative research designs, however, it is difficult for quantitative empirical analyses to distinguish the relative contribution of these two mechanisms.

2.3 The Rise of Right-Wing Populism

Beyond the influence of traditional gender norms and unions' recent efforts to promote gender equality, union members' attitudes toward women's employment may also be shaped by broader political developments. One particularly relevant trend is the rise of right-wing populism, a political movement typically characterized by anti-elitism, nationalism, and authoritarianism (Berman, 2021). Over the past two decades, right-wing populist parties have gained substantial electoral support across many Western democracies. Scholars have attributed this rise to the interaction of economic and cultural forces. Economically, the transition from postwar welfare capitalism to neoliberalism has raised income inequality and eroded social protection, generating widespread economic insecurity (Streeck, 2017). Culturally, the growing social and political influence of women, immigrants, and other marginalized groups has challenged traditional social hierarchies and unsettled dominant groups like white men (Gidron & Hall, 2017; Guriev & Papaioannou, 2022; Inglehart & Norris, 2016). As confidence in mainstream political institutions

has declined, many dissatisfied voters have turned to right-wing populist parties that promise to restore both economic security and traditional social order (Berman, 2019).

Gender has become a central component of this political appeal. Rather than treating gender equality as social progress, right-wing populists frequently portray it as evidence that political elites have abandoned the interests of “ordinary” workers and families. By invoking nostalgia for a society characterized by clearly differentiated gender roles and stable family structures, populist leaders mobilize opposition to rapid cultural change while simultaneously forging alliances with religious organizations, pro-family movements, and other conservative groups (Sauer, 2020; Smeekes et al., 2021). Across many Western countries, these narratives have translated into political efforts to downplay or deny gender inequality, weaken gender-equality institutions, challenge feminist movements, and promote traditional family roles (Askola, 2019; Cabezas, 2022; Korolczuk & Graff, 2018; Kováts, 2018; Lombardo et al., 2021; Möser, 2020; Ratliff et al., 2019; Trappolin, 2022; Valentino et al., 2018).

These developments may be particularly consequential for union members as they have experienced many of these structural changes more directly than other workers. Globalization, de-industrialization, and regional economic integration have weakened unions' bargaining power by increasing capital mobility, intensifying international competition, and reducing the capacity of collective bargaining institutions to protect workers' wages and employment (Streeck, 2017). For many union members, these developments have meant more than economic insecurity. They have also eroded collective bargaining as a key institutional mechanism through which workers could exercise collective voice to improve their wages and working conditions. As this source of economic influence has weakened, union members may become more receptive to right-wing

populist narratives that promise to restore workers' voice and control over their economic futures compared to non-members.

At the same time, many unions have undergone profound internal transformation, increasingly recruiting women, promoting gender equality, and incorporating issues such as equal pay, work-life balance, and sexual harassment into collective bargaining agendas. Although these initiatives have strengthened unions' commitment to gender equality, they may also generate tension among some members when introduced alongside deteriorating economic conditions. In such cases, rather than viewing gender equality initiatives as complementary to traditional bargaining objectives, union members may perceive them as competing with efforts to defend wages, job security, and working conditions that they regard as increasingly under threat (Briskin, 2014). Right-wing populist parties could thus exploit this perceived tension by framing gender equality and other forms of inclusion as distractions from, or even contributors to, organized labor's declining capacity to protect workers' economic interests.

Direct evidence on whether union members are particularly susceptible to the gender norms promoted by right-wing populist parties remains scarce. Existing research has instead focused primarily on whether union members are more likely than non-members to support right-wing populist parties. The findings, however, are mixed. Using data from 11 Western and Northern European countries, Mosimann et al. (2019) find that union membership is generally associated with lower support for right-wing populist parties, although the relationship varies across the types of workers and depends on the presence of a social democratic model. Similarly, Oesch (2008) argues that unions may reduce support for radical rights by integrating workers into mainstream social and political institutions. Empirically, however, the effect of union membership is inconsistent across countries. Likewise, Bornschier and Kriesi (2013) show no overall association

between union membership and support for radical-right parties among manual workers. More recent evidence, however, suggests that union members may have become increasingly receptive to right-wing populism. For example, Bieling (2023) finds that right-wing populist parties have attracted disproportionate support from members of conservative trade unions in France since 2002. Additionally, Amouret (2025) finds that in the 2024 European Parliament election, more than 18 percent of unionized workers in Germany voted for the far-right Alternative for Germany (AfD), approximately four percentage points higher than the party's overall vote share.

Taken together, these perspectives suggest that the relationship between union membership and attitudes toward women's employment is theoretically ambiguous. Historical gender norms embedded in trade unionism point toward less egalitarian attitudes among union members, whereas union leaders' more recent efforts to improve gender equality suggest the opposite through mechanisms such as organizational socialization and self-selection. The broader political environment complicates both accounts further, however, as the gendered appeals of right-wing populism can work against egalitarian attitudes even within unions that have formally committed to gender equality and rejected traditional gender values. Consequently, whether union members hold more egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment than non-members remains an empirical question. The following analysis examines this relationship in the European context and considers what these competing theoretical perspectives imply for the findings.

3. European Value Study Data and Measures

3.1 Sample Construction and Key Variables

I analyze data from the European Value Study Waves 2-5 (EVS 2-5), covering the period between 1990 and 2020. The EVS is a repeated cross-sectional survey that contains extensive information

on individuals' preferences, attitudes, and beliefs. The target population of the EVS is adult residents in Europe. To collect representative data, the EVS employs rigorous single- or multi-stage probability sampling methods. The EVS research team also centrally oversees the translation process and survey implementation to ensure cross-country comparability (EVS, 2022). The EVS can thus provide a broader comparative perspective by enabling the identification of both common patterns and national divergences, offering insights that would be less visible in a single-country study.

In this study, I focus on a sample of 39,877 individuals in 14 Western European countries: Austria, Belgium, Denmark, Finland, France, Germany, Ireland, Italy, the Netherlands, Norway, Portugal, Spain, Sweden, and the UK. These countries have been frequently represented across EVS waves and are commonly included in prior research using the EVS or similar datasets (e.g., Artiles & Molina, 2011; Donnelly, 2016; Frangi et al., 2017; Pontusson, 2013). I exclude most Eastern European or periphery countries with historical ties to communist regimes, under which trade unions often functioned as instruments of state control and union participation was quasi-compulsory. Many of these countries once exhibited exceptionally high union density rates, followed by substantial de-unionization after the collapse of the Soviet Union. Importantly, under the influence of communist regimes, these countries used to have a more widespread gender parity ideology. As a result, union membership may have had much less or no independent effect on gender attitudes in these contexts.

The EVS data provide a measure of attitudes toward women's employment. Respondents are asked to indicate their level of agreement with the statement: "When jobs are scarce, men should have more right to a job than women" (1 = agree, 2 = neither agree nor disagree, 3 = disagree). Those who disagree with this statement are considered to hold more egalitarian or

supportive attitudes toward women's employment. This item has been widely employed in prior studies as a core measure of gender attitudes (for example, see Arpino et al., 2015; Azmat et al., 2006; Burda & Hamermesh, 2014; Fortin, 2005; Leschke & Jepsen, 2014; Lyness & Judiesch, 2014). Importantly, for the present study, this measure directly reflects the masculinized conception of work that has historically fueled gender antagonism in trade unionism—an aspect that alternative indicators of gender attitudes may not fully capture.¹

Union membership, the key independent variable, is a dummy variable equal to 1 if the respondent reports to belong to trade unions. Control variables are summarized in Table 1. In addition to standard demographic and socioeconomic variables, I obtain information on respondents' current/previous occupations. I then create a measure of occupational skill levels (a categorical variable: 1 = low, 2 = medium, 3 = high) based on the International Standard Classification of Occupations (ISCO) schema.² Specifically, low-skilled occupations (ISCO skill level 1) include elementary occupations such as cleaners, helpers, and laborers. Medium-skilled occupations (ISCO skill level 2) include clerical workers, service and sales workers, craft workers, and plant and machine operators. High-skilled occupations (ISCO skill levels 3 and 4) include managers, professionals, and technicians and associate professionals.

Finally, I construct several variables measuring institutional characteristics of industrial relations. The first variable is the female labor force participation rate for individuals aged 15 or above, obtained from the OECD database and calculated at the country-wave level. This variable serves as a general measure of women's integration into the labor market and broader societal

¹ Supporting this interpretation, Table A1 in the appendix shows that the item measuring attitudes toward women's employment exhibits relatively low correlations with other items measuring gender attitudes. This suggests that item measuring attitudes toward women's employment has substantial unique variance not explained by a common latent factor underlying other items measuring gender attitudes, reinforcing its conceptual distinctiveness and relevance for the present analysis.

² See the [ISCO correspondence table for occupations and skill levels](#) for more information.

norms concerning women’s employment. The second variable is the share of union members who are female, obtained from the Institutional Characteristics of Trade Unions, Wage Setting, State Intervention and Social Pacts (ICTWSS) database and calculated at the country-wave level. As women constitute an increasingly important segment of trade union membership, union members’ gender attitudes may be influenced by this demographic shift. Using the ICTWSS database, I further include a third variable that indicates the degree of collective bargaining centralization, i.e., the extent to which “national or industry-level agreements regulate employment terms and conditions” (Doellgast & Benassi, 2020, p. 241). This country-wave level variable is measured on a 5-point scale (0 = least centralized, 5 = most centralized).³ I also include a variable for union density, i.e., the percentage of workers who are union members, which is often viewed as a key measure of the strength of organized labor. Additionally, I empirically calculate the share of women in each occupation based on the EVS data. Listwise deletion is used to handle missing values.

3.2 Getting the Picture

Do union members differ from non-members in their attitudes toward women’s employment? Table 1 shows that, while both groups hold relatively egalitarian views, union members exhibit more egalitarian attitudes than non-members (difference in means = $2.742 - 2.548 = 0.194$, $p < 0.01$). However, this attitude gap is based on a raw comparison between union members and non-members across countries and waves. Table 2 thus further presents the average union-nonunion attitude gap in each country-wave. To facilitate the interpretation, cells with values above and

³ In the ICTWSS, the measure of collective bargaining centralization takes into account (1) the dominant level bargaining, (2) the incidence of and control over additional bargaining at enterprise level, (3) the space that central or sectoral agreements allow for additional bargaining to take place at a lower level, and (4) the degree to which agreements can be perforated through the use of opening clauses. See the [ICTWSS codebook](#) for more information.

below the median union-nonunion gender attitude gap (0.098) are shaded in blue and red, respectively. Darker shades indicate larger deviations from the median.

Two findings from Table 2 merit attention. First, most of the union–nonunion attitude gaps are positive, indicating that union members generally hold more egalitarian views on women’s employment than non-members even in the same country-wave. Second, the above-median gaps (i.e., blue cells) are concentrated in the years preceding the 2008 financial crisis, whereas the below-median gaps (i.e., red cells) appear more frequently in the years following the crisis. This pattern suggests that the positive union–nonunion gap in egalitarian attitudes has narrowed over time. While this development seems to be consistent with the growing influence of right-wing populism discussed earlier, an alternative explanation is that gender attitudes have become more egalitarian overall, leaving unions with less scope to further increase their members’ support for women’s employment. However, this account may be insufficient to explain why some of the union-nonunion gender attitude gaps have turned negative over time.

While the comparison provides a useful descriptive overview, it does not account for any differences in demographic and socioeconomic characteristics between union members and non-members. To offer a more rigorous assessment, I use regression analysis to further examine the relationship between union membership and attitudes toward women’s employment. Specifically, I estimate OLS models comparing the attitudes toward women’s employment between union members and non-members within the same country and averaged across waves (i.e., controlling for country and wave fixed effects), conditional on the control variables in Table 1. I prefer OLS regression due to its ease of interpretation, and the main findings remain robust to alternative estimation techniques, including ordered or multinomial logit regression that relaxes the linearity assumption and Tobit regression that addresses potential censoring of the dependent variable.

My overarching goal is to assess whether union members differ in their attitudes toward women's employment from otherwise similar non-members on average, be it due to selection effects (e.g., individuals with particular gender attitudes being more likely to join unions) and/or causal effects (e.g., the influence of union leadership or right-wing populism). Without additional research designs, one cannot easily isolate these effects. However, as I will discuss later, heterogeneity analyses may help reveal some of the mechanisms underlying the association between union membership and attitudes toward women's employment.

4. Regression Analysis of Attitudes toward Women's Employment

4.1 Main Results based on the Pooled EVS data

Do union members hold more egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment than non-members on average, even after adjusting for differences in demographic and socioeconomic characteristics? The regression results in Table 3 suggest that they do. Column 1 shows the estimated OLS coefficients on attitudes toward women's employment in the full sample, controlling for country effects, time effects, and covariates other than self-reported general political orientation. The coefficient of union membership is positive and statistically significant ($b = 0.039, p < 0.01$). This suggests that union members hold more egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment than non-members on average, holding demographic and socioeconomic characteristics fixed (except for general political orientation). The effect size is also not negligible: It amounts to about 40 percent of the conditional difference in attitudes toward women's employment between females and males, or about 60 percent of the conditional difference between individuals with upper-level education and those with middle-level education. Furthermore, columns 2 and 3 indicate that the positive association is not driven by male or female union

members alone, as the coefficient of union membership remains positive and significant when the male and female samples are analyzed separately.

Is the positive association between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment a result of union members' more progressive political orientation? To address this question, column 4 in Table 3 additionally controls for self-reported general political orientation (ranging from 1 = far left to 10 = far right). The estimated coefficient of union membership shrinks by about one third but remains positive and significant ($b = 0.025$, $p < 0.01$). The magnitude is comparable to the difference associated with a one-point increase on the left-right scale (i.e., moving to a more conservative position). Columns 5 and 6 further indicate a similar pattern in both the male and female samples. Overall, these results demonstrate that union members hold more egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment than non-members within the same country during the 1990-2020 period, even after accounting for differences in general political orientation and other observed dimensions, on average.⁴

Note that the results in Table 3 are based on a pooled analysis that averages within-country comparisons between union members and non-members. While this approach provides a useful summary, it masks cross-country variability and raises the concern that the positive association may be driven by only a few countries. To address this issue, I further interact union membership with country dummies in OLS regression. This allows the association between union membership and attitudes toward women's employment to vary by country. Figure 1 presents the marginal effects (MEs) of union membership for each country. The figure shows that the MEs are positive in 10 out of the 14 countries. The MEs are relatively larger in three countries (Portugal, Italy, and Belgium), while smaller and similar to the pooled OLS estimate in six countries (Austria, France,

⁴ The subsequent analyses always control for general political orientation. All results are substantively similar with and without general political orientation as a control variable.

Spain, the Netherlands, Germany, and the UK). By contrast, the MEs are close to zero or even negative in the remaining five countries (Ireland, Denmark, Finland, Sweden, and Norway).⁵

Overall, the analysis indicates a degree of cross-country variability but confirms that the positive association from the pooled OLS regression is not driven by a small subset of countries in the sample. In what follows, I conduct additional heterogeneity analyses to understand how both individual and institutional characteristics may influence the relationship between union membership and attitudes toward women's employment. These analyses are organized around the factors theorized to influence union members' gender attitudes, namely the ideal worker and breadwinner norms, the role of union leadership, and the rise of right-wing populism.

4.2 Individual Heterogeneity

How might the relationship between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment vary across individuals? Recall that the ideal worker account suggests that gender antagonism in trade unionism is rooted in a strong commitment to work and skill development. From this perspective, the positive association between union membership and egalitarian gender attitudes could be weaker for individuals in high-skilled occupations, as they are more likely to internalize the ideal worker norm due to their greater investment in skill acquisition and unique work identities (Ashcraft, 2013). Motivated by this view, I regress egalitarian gender attitudes toward women's employment on the two-way interaction between union membership and

⁵ Excluding countries with relatively larger positive and negative MEs (i.e., Portugal, Italy, Belgium, Denmark, Finland, Sweden, and Norway) from the pooled analysis still yields a positive and statistically significant OLS coefficient of union membership on egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment ($b = 0.050$, $p < 0.01$).

occupational skill levels, controlling for country effects, time effects, and other covariates (including lower-level terms from the two-way interaction).⁶

Figure 2 shows the MEs of union membership on attitudes toward women's employment by skill level. Panel A indicates that in the full sample, the MEs are positive among the low- and medium-skilled, but negative among the high-skilled (all p -values < 0.05). That is, union membership is associated with more egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment among low- and medium-skilled individuals, while it is linked to less egalitarian attitudes among high-skilled individuals. Moreover, as shown in panels B and C, this pattern generally holds in both the male and female samples. This absence of gender differences is not entirely surprising, as the emphasis on work devotion applies to both men and women (Manchester et al., 2013). Together, these results are consistent with the ideal worker account, highlighting work devotion as an important factor in shaping the relationship between union membership and attitudes toward women's employment.

Alternatively, the breadwinner account argues that gender antagonism in trade unionism arises from the perceived threat that women pose to men's role as the primary wage earner. This perspective suggests that the positive association between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment could be weaker if manhood cannot be affirmed through paid work. To examine this possibility, I regress egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment on the two-way interaction between union membership and occupational share of women. Prior research shows that men working in female-typed occupations often struggle to conform to conventional gender expectations, as they tend to be stereotyped as feminine (Fan, 2022; Ueno et al., 2018). Consequently, the positive association between union membership and egalitarian

⁶ More detailed regression results for this and subsequent individual/institutional-level heterogeneity analyses are presented in Tabel A2 in the appendix.

attitudes toward women's employment should be less likely for individuals in occupations with a larger share of women. Importantly, this pattern should be driven primarily by men whose breadwinner identity is potentially challenged.

Figure 3 shows the MEs of union membership on attitudes toward women's employment across different shares of women in the occupation (small = at the 25th percentile, medium = at the 50th percentile, large = at the 75th percentile). Panel A indicates that in the full sample, the ME becomes less positive when the occupational share of women increases. In other words, the positive association between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment weakens when the share of women in the occupations is larger. When the share of women is small or medium, the association between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment are positive and significant (both $p < 0.05$). However, when the share of women is large, the association becomes less positive and insignificant ($p > 0.1$). Panels B and C further confirm that this pattern holds only in the male sample. In the female sample, the association between union membership and gender attitudes does not change significantly with the share of women in the occupation. These results are in line with the breadwinner account, highlighting the importance of gender role expectations in shaping union members' attitudes toward women's employment.

4.3 Institutional Heterogeneity

Institutional contexts can also shape the extent to which ideal worker and breadwinner norms are expressed, thereby influencing the relationship between union membership and attitudes toward women's employment. One relevant institutional factor is the centralization of collective bargaining, i.e., the degree to which "national or industry-level agreements regulate employment terms and conditions" (Doellgast & Benassi, 2020, p. 241). Under centralized collective bargaining,

a positive association between union membership and egalitarian gender attitudes is more likely for at least two reasons. First, when employers are constrained by higher-level agreements, they are granted with less discretion in wage setting (Wallerstein, 1990). This reduces workers' incentive to invest in occupation- or firm-specific human capital, as the economic returns to such investment could not be fully captured (Becker, 1962). As a result, centralized collective bargaining may lessen the influence of the ideal worker norm, which excludes women from employment on the basis of skill development and preservation.

Second, prior research shows that centralized collective bargaining can reduce the gender pay gap and increase women's employment (Blau & Kahn, 2003; Garner, 2021). Importantly, these outcomes are achieved through coordinated negotiations that incorporate broader societal concerns rather than employer decisions shaped by competitive market pressures (Erikson, 2021). As a result, these gains are more likely to legitimize and reinforce women's participation and integration in paid work—rather than provoke backlash—since gender equality is embedded in higher-level bargaining agendas as a shared collective objective. In this way, centralized collective bargaining can more effectively challenge the breadwinner norm that considers men as the sole provider and excludes women from employment.

Based on this reasoning, I regress attitudes toward women's employment on the two-way interaction between union membership and centralization of collective bargaining, controlling for country effects, time effects, and all other covariates. This specification leverages within-country variation in the degree of collective bargaining centralization over time, ruling out the influence of other stable cross-country institutional differences. Panel A of Figure 4 presents the MEs of union membership across different levels of collective bargaining centralization (low = at the 25th percentile, medium = at the 50th percentile, high = at the 75th percentile). The results indicate that

when collective bargaining is less centralized (at the 25th percentile), union members do not differ significantly from non-members in their support for women's employment ($p > 0.1$). In contrast, when collective bargaining is more centralized (at the 50th or 75th percentile), union members exhibit significantly more egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment than non-members (both $p < 0.05$). These findings support the notion that union members tend to have more egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment than non-members when collective bargaining is more centralized.

Another relevant institutional factor is union density. As discussed earlier, union leaders can play a crucial role in shaping members' gender attitudes, especially when they are motivated by a strategic need to revitalize union power by including traditionally marginalized groups like women. Following this logic, in contexts where organized labor is relatively strong, union leaders may have less incentive in promoting gender equality as a collective goal, thus weakening the positive association between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment. To examine this possibility, I regress gender attitudes on the two-way interaction between union membership and union density—a key measure of the strength of organized labor. Panel B of Figure 4 presents the MEs of union membership on attitudes toward women's employment across different levels of union density (low = at the 25th percentile, medium = at the 50th percentile, high = at the 75th percentile). The results indicate that the positive association between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment attenuates but remains significant when union density increases (all $p < 0.05$). This pattern offers suggestive evidence that union leadership influences members' gender attitudes, with union revitalization serving as an instrumental motivation for leaders to promote gender equality.

4.4 Assessing the Influence of the Right-Wing Populism

Earlier discussions suggest that right-wing populism may have complicated the progress toward gender equality among union members in recent years. To further explore this trend, I regress attitudes toward women's employment on the two-way interaction between union membership and wave dummies, controlling for country effects and all other covariates. This allows the coefficient of union membership to vary over time. Figure 5 presents the MEs of union membership by wave from on this analysis. The results indicate that the positive association between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment has attenuated since the 2008 financial crisis. Notably, in the 2017-2020 period, the association turns negative and significant for both male and female samples ($p < 0.1$ and $p < 0.05$, respectively). This suggests that union members held less egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment than non-members during this recent period on average. One possible explanation is that the 2008 financial crisis marked a critical turning point, creating fertile ground for right-wing populist narratives to link economic insecurity with conservative social values—potentially reshaping many union members' gender attitudes.

To provide further evidence, I examine whether the erosion of the union–nonunion gap in gender attitudes over time varies with the level of right-wing populist influence. If right-wing populism is a driving force behind the observed trend, the union–nonunion gender attitude gap should narrow mostly in countries where right-wing populist parties exert greater influence. To test this possibility, I classify countries into low, medium, and high levels of right-wing populist influence based on the vote share received by right-wing populist parties in the 2009, 2014, and 2019 European Parliament Elections (Zulianello & Larsen, 2021). Countries with low influence (< 5% of the votes) are Germany, Ireland, Portugal, and Spain; those with medium influence (5%–15% of the votes) are Belgium, Finland, the Netherlands, and Sweden; and those with high

influence (> 15% of the votes) are Austria, Denmark, France, Italy, and the UK.⁷ Within each group of countries, I regress attitudes toward women's employment on the two-way interaction between union membership and a dummy indicator for the post-financial crisis period (0 = EVS 2–3; 1 = EVS 4–5).

Table 4 presents the results of this analysis. The key variable of interest is the interaction term between union membership and the post-financial crisis dummy, which captures the change in the union-nonunion gender attitude gap over time. One important finding is that the direction and extent of the change are systematically related to the level of right-wing populist influence. Column 1 shows that in countries with low levels of right-wing populist influence, the interaction term is positive and significant ($b = 0.107, p < 0.05$), suggesting that the union-nonunion gender attitude gap did not shrink and instead widened over the period. By contrast, column 2 shows that in countries with medium levels of right-wing populist influence, the interaction term is negative and significant ($b = -0.077, p < 0.05$), indicating a narrowed union-nonunion gap in attitudes toward women's employment. Column 3 further shows that the erosion of the union-nonunion gap is most pronounced in countries with high levels of right-wing populist influence, since the interaction term is negative and largest in magnitude ($b = -0.232, p < 0.01$). These results thus provide suggestive evidence that right-wing populism has impeded union members' progress toward more egalitarian gender attitudes, particularly after the 2008 financial crisis.

4.5 Robustness Checks

Alternative measure of gender attitudes. The preceding analyses rely on a single survey item to measure gender attitudes. Although this study primarily focuses on the belief that men are more

⁷ Norway is excluded from this analysis as it is not a member of the European Union.

entitled to employment than women, the use of a single-item measure raises potential concerns regarding measurement validity and selective item choice. To address these concerns, I employ an alternative measure of gender attitudes based on respondents' level of agreement with the statement: "A job is alright, but what most women really want is a home and children" (coded from 1 = strongly agree to 4 = strongly disagree, i.e., larger values indicate more egalitarian gender attitudes). Compared to other gender-related items in the EVS, this alternative measure is consistently administered across waves, allowing researchers to track temporal dynamics. However, whereas the primary measure captures attitudes toward women's employment *relative to men's*, this alternative measure focuses more *directly on* normative beliefs regarding women's social and familial roles. As such, this alternative measure is related but conceptually different from the primary measure concerning women's employment.

Using this alternative measure, I use OLS regression to estimate the coefficient of union membership on gender attitudes, pooling across countries and waves and controlling for all covariates. The results indicate that union membership is positively correlated with egalitarian gender attitudes in the full sample ($b = 0.051, p < 0.01$), male sample ($b = 0.037, p < 0.05$), and female sample ($b = 0.066, p < 0.01$), consistent with the results presented in Table 3. Furthermore, I regress this alternative measure on the two-way interaction between union membership and wave dummies, controlling for country effects and all other covariates. This allows the coefficient of union membership on gender attitudes to vary over time. Figure A1 in the appendix presents the MEs of union membership by wave and gender. The figure similarly shows an erosion in the union-nonunion gap in gender attitudes, such that union members did not differ from non-members in gender attitudes in the 2017-2020 period. Overall, these results are in line with those in the preceding analyses.

Alternative analytical sample. As union membership in Europe has a broad social basis and is not always tied to current employment status, the analyses thus far have included individuals both in and out of the labor force. To ensure that the main findings are not sensitive to this sample choice, I conduct a robustness test by restricting the analysis only to respondents who were employed at the time of the interview ($N = 28214$). Using this sample and pooling across countries and waves, OLS regression results indicate that union membership is positively correlated with egalitarian gender attitudes in the full sample ($b = 0.023, p < 0.05$), male sample ($b = 0.033, p < 0.05$), and female sample ($b = 0.024, p < 0.05$), consistent with the results presented in Table 3. Moreover, to examine the time dynamics, I regress gender attitudes on the two-way interaction between union membership and wave dummies. Figure A2 in the appendix shows the MEs of union membership by wave and gender. The figure also confirms that the positive association between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment has attenuated since the 2008 financial crisis.

5. Discussion and Conclusion

The present study uniquely theorizes and empirically examines the relationship between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment. Drawing on insights from multiple disciplines, it proposes that a masculinized conception of work—viewing work as primarily for men—has historically underpinned gender antagonism in trade unionism. This conception of work has been grounded in two enduring social norms: the ideal worker norm, which emphasizes unwavering commitment to work and resonates with craft unionism's emphasis on skill development; and the breadwinner norm, which positions men as primary earners and women as non-working wives—a belief popularized by trade unionists through the family wage movement.

While recent socioeconomic developments have led many union leaders to advocate gender equality, uncertainty remains regarding whether union members hold more egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment than non-members or not. In particular, the rise of right-wing populism may have hindered the progress toward gender equality among union members by mobilizing economic insecurity and promoting conservative social values.

Motivated by these perspectives, I empirically analyze the relationship between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment using data on approximately 40,000 individuals in 14 Western European countries between 1990 and 2020. Pooling across waves, I find that union members hold more egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment than non-members in the same country with similar demographic and socioeconomic backgrounds, on average. Moreover, this relationship varies across both individual characteristics and institutional contexts. At the individual level, the association is less positive for high-skilled individuals and for men in occupations with a large share of women. At the institutional level, the association is more positive under more centralized collective bargaining but less positive in the presence of higher union density. Finally, I document a post-financial crisis shift in which the positive association between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment has attenuated or even reversed. This change is particularly pronounced in countries where right-wing populism exerts greater influence.

These findings carry both theoretical and practical implications. Theoretically, the study extends recent industrial relations scholarship that calls for greater attention to social identity in IR research by examining the tension between trade unions' historical gender antagonism and their contemporary pursuit of inclusive solidarity. Lee and Tapia (2021) argue that conventional IR theories often treat workers as a homogeneous class with shared economic interests and assume

trade unions to be inclusive organizations, thereby overlooking identity-based inequalities within the labor movement. The present study advances this discussion by explaining how gender antagonism became embedded in trade unionism through the interaction between prevailing social norms and unions' own philosophies and practices. In particular, the ideal worker norm aligned with craft unionism's emphasis on skill development and commitment to work, while the breadwinner norm was reinforced through unions' pursuit of the family wage. Trade unions therefore did not merely inherit prevailing gender norms but also helped reinforce a masculinized conception of work that viewed employment as primarily for men.

More recently, women's growing labor force participation, changes in public policy, and unions' need for revitalization have led many union leaders to pursue inclusive solidarity by expanding women's representation and incorporating their interests into union agendas. These developments may place unions' contemporary efforts to promote gender equality in tension with their historical legacy of gender antagonism. One manifestation of this tension is a potential divergence between union leaders' commitment to gender equality and union members' attitudes toward women's employment. Despite union leaders' support for gender equality, union members' attitudes may continue to be shaped by practices and cultures that carry organized labor's gendered legacies, particularly those associated with the ideal worker and breadwinner norms. This points to an important gap in existing research: Although scholars have documented unions' organizational efforts to advance gender equality, much less is known about the gender attitudes of individual union members. Addressing this gap is important because union members' support for women's employment is crucial for building and sustaining inclusive solidarity.

By comparing union members' attitudes toward women's employment with those of non-members, this study reveals whether union members provide a relatively supportive attitudinal

foundation for unions' efforts to build inclusive solidarity. The finding that union members hold more egalitarian attitudes than non-members on average suggests broad alignment with unions' contemporary efforts to promote gender equality. However, the variation across individual, institutional, and political contexts—together with the weakening of the positive association between union membership and egalitarian gender attitudes over time—indicates that gender antagonism in trade unionism has not simply disappeared and that the progress toward gender equality is not uniform. Building and sustaining inclusive solidarity therefore requires continued efforts to strengthen support for gender equality among union members.

Practically, the findings provide union leaders with a benchmark for assessing their members' support for gender equality relative to non-members. The overall positive association suggests that union leaders may have a supportive membership base for pursuing gender equality initiatives, regardless of whether this pattern reflects union leaders' influence, the attraction and retention of workers with more egalitarian gender attitudes, or both. However, the heterogeneity across skill levels, occupational gender composition, collective bargaining centralization, and union density cautions against assuming that support for gender equality and related initiatives is uniform among union members. Union leaders may choose to tailor their gender equality initiatives to differences among members and across institutional settings. This could involve examining whether particular union practices, collective bargaining arrangements, job demands, and industry characteristics continue to reinforce implicit gendered assumptions about work.

Union leaders may also want to actively monitor how broader economic and political developments affect gender attitudes of their members. The weakening of union members' relative advantage in egalitarian attitudes after the financial crisis, especially in countries where right-wing populism is more influential, suggests that previous gains cannot be assumed to persist. Following

major economic or political shifts, union leaders may find it useful to reassess their members' gender attitudes and adjust communication, education, and engagement efforts accordingly.

The present study is not without limitations, however. One prominent limitation concerns the mechanisms underlying the overall positive association between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment. This association could arise through a causal channel, a self-selection channel, or both operating together. Under the causal channel, union leaders' prioritization of gender equality in collective bargaining, organizational governance, and public communication may actively shape members' attitudes through socialization and participation. Under the self-selection channel, unions that are more gender inclusive may simply attract and retain workers who already share those egalitarian attitudes, in which case the observed association reflects sorting rather than a causal effect of membership on attitudes. The present analysis cannot fully distinguish between these two channels, and future quantitative research could evaluate their relative importance by leveraging panel data, experimental designs, and more advanced causal identification strategies.

Nevertheless, the positive association between union membership and egalitarian attitudes is meaningful under either account, though for different reasons. If the causal channel dominates, the finding would suggest that union leaders and their initiatives can genuinely move members' attitudes, providing a concrete means for advancing gender equality within the labor movement. If the self-selection channel dominates, the association would instead suggest that workers with more egalitarian attitudes are more likely to join and remain in unions. Although this interpretation does not imply that union leaders can effectively change their members' attitudes, it provides important information about the composition of their membership. Such a membership base may

itself constitute an organizational resource, helping union leaders to build and sustain inclusive solidarity through recruitment, retention, and collective action.

Another limitation of the study concerns the cross-national analysis. Rather than focusing on a single national context, the findings reflect average patterns across a set of Western European countries that share broad institutional and cultural similarities. Consequently, the estimated relationship between union membership and attitudes toward women's employment may mask important country-specific variation arising from differences in labor market institutions, union strategies, historical trajectories, political environments, and gender-equality policies. Although the study accounts for country fixed effects, these estimates should not be interpreted as implying that the relationship is identical across countries. Future research could build on this study by examining how other institutional conditions and individual characteristics influence the relationship between union membership and attitudes toward women's employment.

Despite these limitations, the study shows that the relationship between union membership and egalitarian attitudes toward women's employment is neither uniform nor stable. Although union members hold more egalitarian attitudes than non-members on average, this relationship varies over time and across individual, institutional, and political contexts. This in part reflects the continuing tension between trade union's historical legacy of gender antagonism and their contemporary efforts to build a more inclusive labor movement. Attending to this tension may help union leaders develop gender equality initiatives that are more responsive to differences in their membership base and changes in the broader socioeconomic environment.

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Table 1. Means of Variables

	Full Sample (1)	Union Members (2)	Non-Members (3)
Attitudes toward women's employment	2.595	2.742	2.548
Union member	0.243		
Female	0.477	0.459	0.483
<i>Age</i>			
15-29 years old	0.151	0.127	0.159
30-49 years old	0.409	0.464	0.392
50+ years old	0.440	0.409	0.449
<i>Education level</i>			
Lower	0.321	0.245	0.346
Medium	0.355	0.326	0.364
Upper	0.324	0.429	0.290
<i>Marital status</i>			
Married	0.606	0.653	0.591
Single	0.233	0.222	0.237
Divorced/separated/widowed	0.161	0.126	0.173
Having any child	0.724	0.754	0.714
Religious person	0.561	0.538	0.569
<i>Employment status</i>			
Full-time	0.538	0.717	0.480
Part-time	0.099	0.087	0.102
Self-employed	0.071	0.029	0.085
Unemployed	0.028	0.021	0.031
Not in the labor force	0.264	0.145	0.302
<i>Household income</i>			
Low	0.270	0.182	0.299
Medium	0.364	0.399	0.353
High	0.366	0.418	0.349
<i>Occupational skill level</i>			
Low	0.084	0.057	0.093
Medium	0.557	0.542	0.561
High	0.359	0.401	0.346
<i>Institutions</i>			
Female labor force participation rate	51.551	54.736	50.527
Share of union members who are female	42.878	44.841	42.247
Share of women in the occupation	50.160	49.415	50.400
Centralization of collective bargaining	2.589	2.546	2.603
Union density	37.443	49.339	33.621
Political orientation (1 = left to 10 = right)	5.270	4.998	5.358
Observations	39877	9696	30181

Notes: This table presents the means of variables in the full sample and by union membership. Individual-level data are from the EVS 2-5, and institutional-level data are calculated based on the ICTWSS and OECD databases. The sample is respondents in 14 Western European countries: AT, BE, DK, FI, FR, DE, IE, IT, NL, NO, PT, SE, SW, and GB. Results are not weighted.

Table 2. Union-Nonunion Gap in Egalitarian Attitudes toward Women's Employment by Country and over Time

	EVS-2: 1990-1993	EVS-3: 1999-2001	EVS-4: 2008-2010	EVS-5: 2017-2020	Average over Time
Austria	0.277	0.183	-0.114	-0.073	0.068
Belgium	0.105	0.135	0.051	-	0.097
Denmark	0.200	0.121	0.023	0.072	0.104
Finland	-	0.121	-0.004	0.066	0.061
France	0.060	0.099	0.098	0.173	0.108
Germany	0.046	0.098	0.032	0.028	0.051
Ireland	0.148	0.104	-0.065	-	0.062
Italy	0.121	0.148	0.086	0.238	0.148
Netherlands	0.110	0.023	-0.021	0.030	0.036
Norway	0.025	-	0.021	0.032	0.026
Portugal	0.376	0.512	0.225	-	0.371
Spain	0.114	0.152	0.180	0.316	0.191
Sweden	-	-	0.013	0.049	0.031
United Kingdom	0.157	0.130	0.087	0.046	0.105
Average across Countries	0.198	0.255	0.147	0.150	0.188

Notes: This table reports the average union–nonunion gap in egalitarian attitudes toward women’s employment by country and over time. Positive values indicate that union members hold more egalitarian views than non-members on average, without adjusting other factors. The country-wave median union-nonunion attitude gap is 0.098. Values greater than the median are shaded in blue, with darker shades representing larger positive gaps; values below the median are shaded in red, with darker shades indicating larger negative gaps. Country/time averages are arithmetic means. Results are not weighted.

Table 3. OLS Regression of Attitudes toward Women's Employment on Union Membership

	Across Political Orientation			Within Political Orientation		
	Full Sample	Male Sample	Female Sample	Full Sample	Male Sample	Female Sample
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Union member	0.039*** (0.009)	0.049*** (0.013)	0.031** (0.012)	0.025*** (0.009)	0.034*** (0.013)	0.021* (0.012)
Female	0.105*** (0.008)			0.100*** (0.008)		
<i>Age (Ref.: 15-29 years old)</i>						
30-49 years old	-0.066*** (0.012)	-0.082*** (0.018)	-0.051*** (0.016)	-0.067*** (0.012)	-0.082*** (0.017)	-0.053*** (0.016)
50+ years old	-0.158*** (0.014)	-0.197*** (0.020)	-0.124*** (0.019)	-0.154*** (0.014)	-0.194*** (0.020)	-0.119*** (0.019)
<i>Education level (Ref.: Lower)</i>						
Middle	0.178*** (0.011)	0.173*** (0.015)	0.178*** (0.015)	0.178*** (0.011)	0.172*** (0.015)	0.179*** (0.015)
Upper	0.238*** (0.011)	0.242*** (0.016)	0.238*** (0.016)	0.232*** (0.011)	0.236*** (0.016)	0.232*** (0.016)
<i>Marital status (Ref.: Married)</i>						
Single	0.033*** (0.011)	0.008 (0.016)	0.054*** (0.015)	0.031*** (0.011)	0.005 (0.016)	0.052*** (0.015)
Divorced/separated/widowed	0.034*** (0.012)	0.018 (0.018)	0.039** (0.016)	0.032*** (0.012)	0.015 (0.018)	0.038** (0.016)
Having any child	-0.015 (0.011)	-0.012 (0.016)	-0.012 (0.015)	-0.014 (0.011)	-0.012 (0.015)	-0.011 (0.015)
Religious person	-0.095*** (0.008)	-0.074*** (0.011)	-0.120*** (0.011)	-0.080*** (0.008)	-0.058*** (0.011)	-0.106*** (0.011)
<i>Employment status (Ref.: Full-time)</i>						
Part-time	0.017 (0.012)	0.062** (0.025)	-0.002 (0.014)	0.013 (0.012)	0.053** (0.025)	-0.005 (0.014)
Self-employed	0.010 (0.015)	0.030 (0.019)	-0.022 (0.024)	0.016 (0.015)	0.039** (0.019)	-0.020 (0.024)
Unemployed	-0.025 (0.025)	0.006 (0.035)	-0.056 (0.035)	-0.029 (0.025)	0.001 (0.035)	-0.060* (0.035)
Not in the labor force	-0.139*** (0.012)	-0.100*** (0.018)	-0.186*** (0.016)	-0.138*** (0.012)	-0.099*** (0.018)	-0.186*** (0.016)
<i>Household income (Ref.: Low)</i>						
Medium	0.062*** (0.011)	0.076*** (0.016)	0.048*** (0.015)	0.063*** (0.011)	0.077*** (0.016)	0.050*** (0.015)
High	0.113*** (0.012)	0.126*** (0.017)	0.093*** (0.016)	0.121*** (0.012)	0.136*** (0.017)	0.100*** (0.016)
<i>Occupation skill level (Ref.: Low)</i>						
Medium	0.075*** (0.017)	0.076*** (0.024)	0.084*** (0.023)	0.078*** (0.017)	0.078*** (0.024)	0.086*** (0.023)
High	0.107*** (0.018)	0.108*** (0.026)	0.105*** (0.025)	0.111*** (0.018)	0.115*** (0.026)	0.107*** (0.025)

Institutions

Female labor force participation rate	0.002 (0.001)	0.002 (0.002)	0.000 (0.002)	0.002* (0.001)	0.003 (0.002)	0.001 (0.002)
Share of union members who are female	0.013*** (0.002)	0.014*** (0.004)	0.010*** (0.003)	0.013*** (0.002)	0.015*** (0.004)	0.011*** (0.003)
Share of women in the occupation	0.001*** (0.000)	0.001*** (0.000)	0.001** (0.001)	0.001*** (0.000)	0.001*** (0.000)	0.001** (0.001)
Centralization of collective bargaining	0.146*** (0.020)	0.176*** (0.028)	0.107*** (0.027)	0.148*** (0.020)	0.178*** (0.028)	0.110*** (0.027)
Union density	-0.005*** (0.002)	-0.006*** (0.002)	-0.004* (0.002)	-0.004*** (0.002)	-0.005** (0.002)	-0.003 (0.002)
Political orientation (1 = left, 10 = right)				-0.025*** (0.002)	-0.028*** (0.003)	-0.023*** (0.003)
Wave effects	×	×	×	×	×	×
Country effects	×	×	×	×	×	×
Observations	39877	20855	19022	39877	20855	19022
R-squared	0.197	0.196	0.201	0.201	0.201	0.204

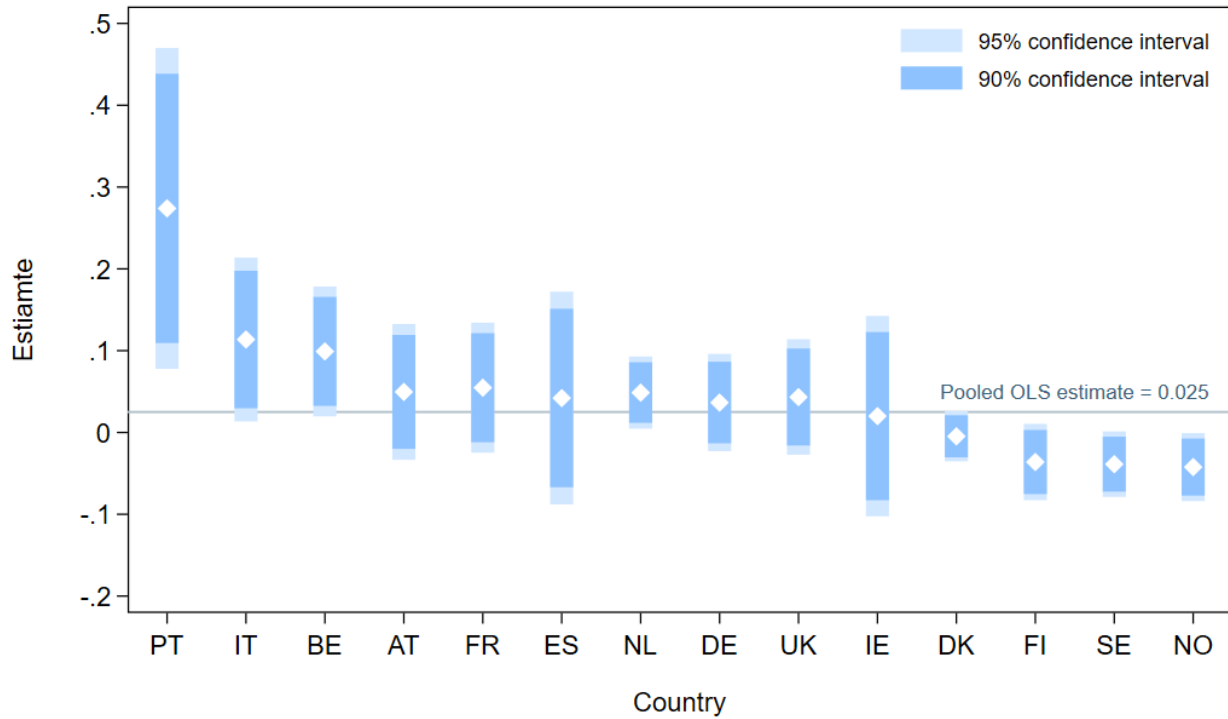
Notes: This table presents the OLS regression results of attitudes toward women's employment on union membership and other covariates, controlling for country effects and wave effects. Columns 1-3 report results for the full sample and separately by gender, without controlling for political orientation. Columns 4-6 report the results after controlling for political orientation. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. *, **, *** indicate significance levels at 0.1, 0.05, and 0.01, respectively. Models are estimated using the EVS weights.

Table 4. OLS Regression of Gender Attitudes on the Two-Way Interaction between Union Membership and the Post-Financial Crisis Dummy, by Right-Wing Populist Influence

	By Share of Votes for Right-Wing Populist Parties		
	Low (< 5%)	Medium (5-15%)	High (> 15%)
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Union member	0.005 (0.033)	0.076** (0.031)	0.125*** (0.025)
Post-financial crisis	-0.336*** (0.059)	0.119*** (0.036)	-0.006 (0.031)
Union member $\times$ Post-financial crisis	0.107** (0.048)	-0.077** (0.034)	-0.169*** (0.028)
Controls	$\times$	$\times$	$\times$
Country effects	$\times$	$\times$	$\times$
Observations	10484	9498	17423
R-squared	0.136	0.188	0.223

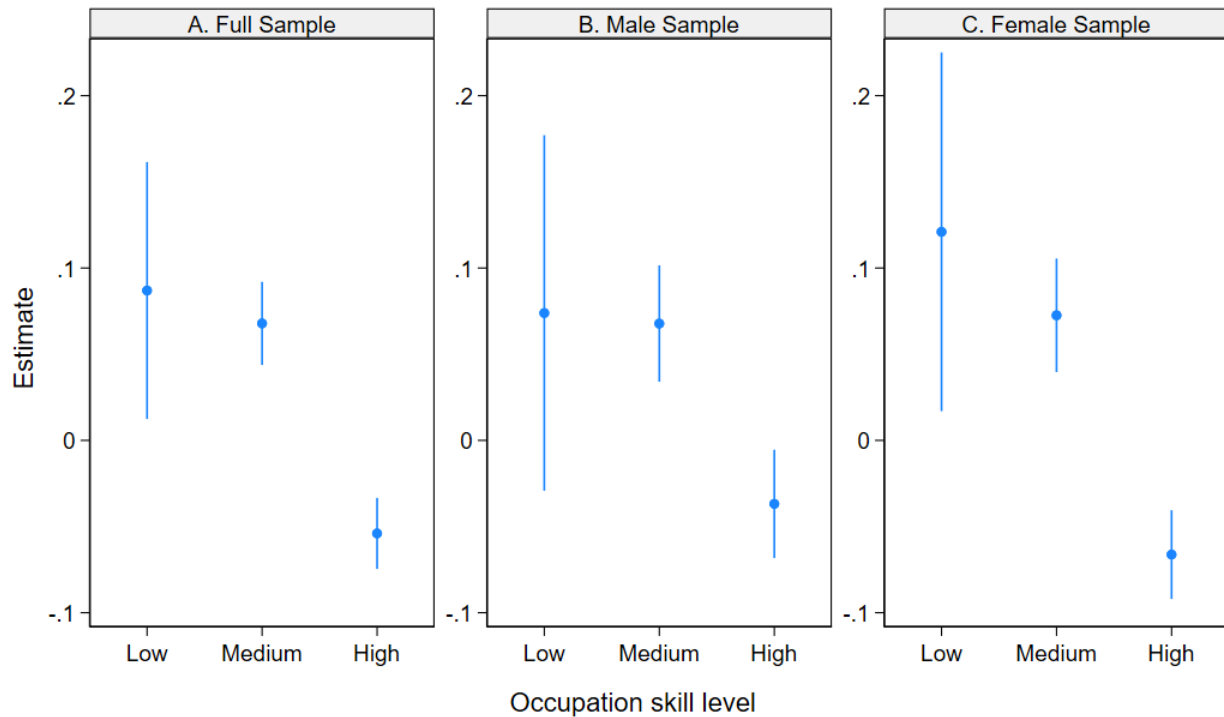
Notes: This table shows the OLS regression results of the attitudes toward women's employment on the two-way interaction between union membership and the post-financial crisis dummy, by the influence of right-wing populism measured as the share of votes received by right-wing populist parties in the 2009, 2014, and 2019 European Parliament Elections (Norway is thus excluded from the analysis). Countries with low influence (< 5% of the votes) are Germany, Ireland, Portugal, and Spain; those with medium influence (5%–15% of the votes) are Belgium, Finland, the Netherlands, and Sweden; and those with high influence (> 15% of the votes) are Austria, Denmark, France, Italy, and the UK. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. *, **, *** indicate significance levels at 0.1, 0.05, and 0.01, respectively. Models are estimated using the EVS weights.

Figure 1. Margin Effects of Union Membership on Attitudes Toward Women's Employment by Country



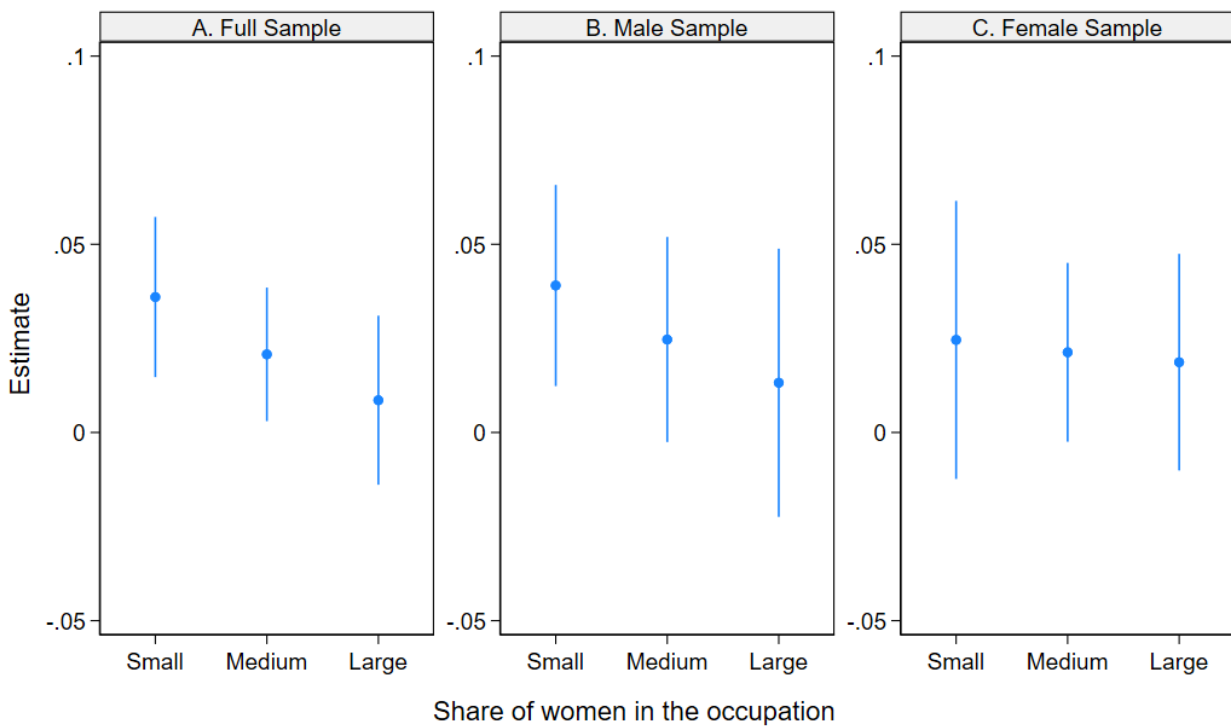
Notes: This figure presents the marginal effects of union membership on attitudes toward women's employment in each country. Estimates are obtained from OLS regression of attitudes toward women's employment on two-way interaction between union membership and country dummies, controlling for wave effects, other covariates (including political orientation), and all lower-level terms from the two-way interaction. Bars indicate the 95% or 90% confidence intervals constructed using robust standard errors. Models are estimated with the EVS weights. The horizontal line indicates the OLS coefficient of union membership on gender attitudes from column 4 of Table 3, pooling across countries and waves. Models are estimated with the EVS weights.

Figure 2. Margin Effects of Union Membership on Attitudes Toward Women's Employment by Skill Level



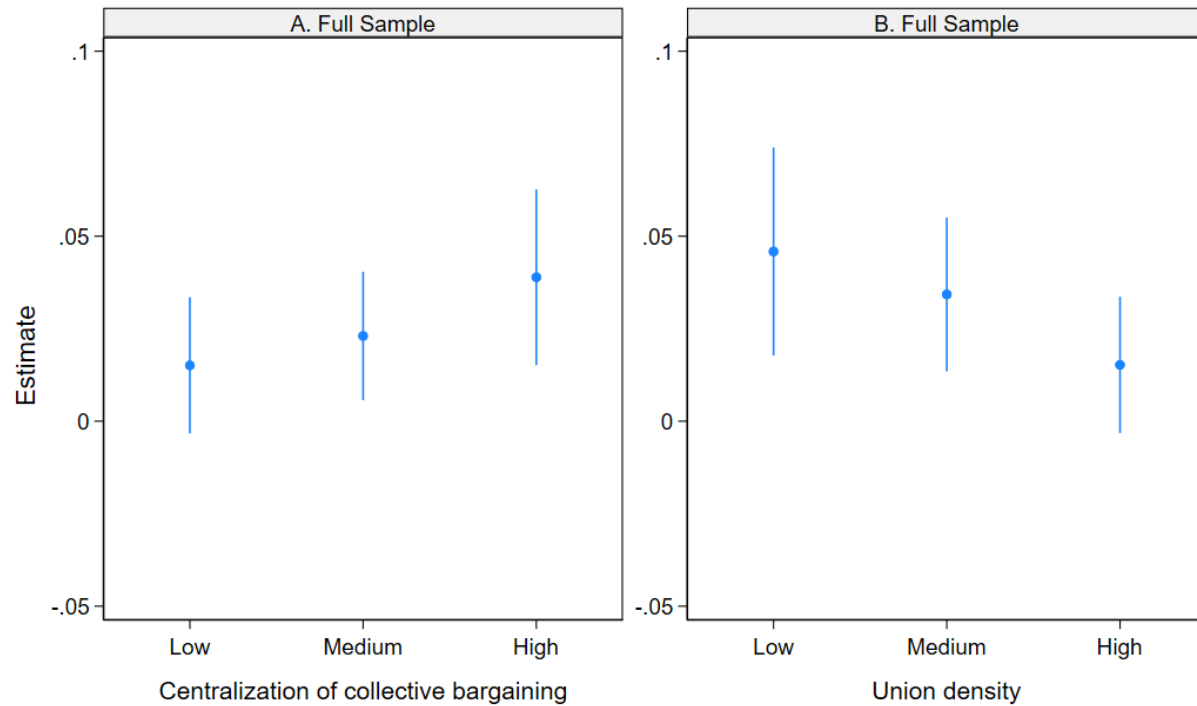
Notes: This figure presents the marginal effects of union membership on attitudes toward women's employment at different skill levels. Panels A, B, and C show the results in the full sample, male sample, and female sample, respectively. Categorization of skill levels is based on the ISCO classification. Estimates are obtained from OLS regression of attitudes toward women's employment on two-way interaction between union membership and skill levels, controlling for country effects, time effects, and all other covariates. Robust standard errors are used. Bars indicate the 95% confidence intervals constructed using robust standard errors. Models are estimated with the EVS weights. More detailed regression results for the full sample are presented in column 1 of Table A2 in the appendix.

Figure 3. Margin Effects of Union Membership on Attitudes Toward Women's Employment
by Occupational Gender Composition



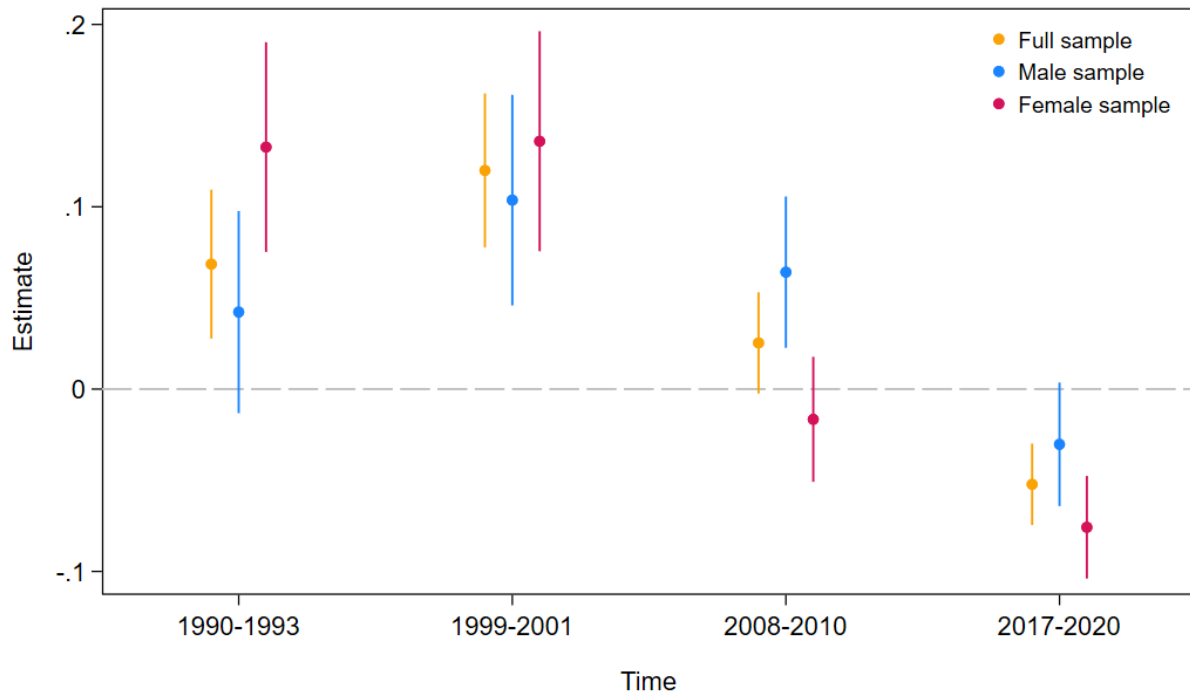
Notes: This figure presents the marginal effects of union membership on attitudes toward women's employment for respondents in occupations with different shares of women (small = at the 25th percentile, medium = at the 25th and 75th percentile, large = at the 75th percentile). Panels A, B, and C show the results in the full sample, male sample, and female sample, respectively. Estimates are obtained from OLS regression of attitudes toward women's employment on two-way interaction between union membership and share of women in the occupation, controlling for country effects, time effects, and all other covariates. Bars indicate the 95% confidence intervals constructed using robust standard errors. Models are estimated with the EVS weights. More detailed regression results for the full sample are presented in column 2 of Table A2 in the appendix.

Figure 4. Margin Effects of Union Membership on Attitudes Toward Women's Employment by Collective Bargaining Centralization and Union Density



Notes: This figure presents the marginal effects of union membership on attitudes toward women's employment at different levels of collective bargaining centralization (panel A) and union density (panel B). Low, medium, and high levels indicate the 25th, 50th, and 75th percentile of the country-wave distribution of institutional characteristics, respectively. Estimates are obtained from OLS regression of attitudes toward women's employment on two-way interaction between union membership and collective bargaining centralization/union density, controlling for country effects, wave effects, all other covariates. Bars indicate the 95% confidence intervals constructed using robust standard errors. Models are estimated with the EVS weights. More detailed regression results are presented in column 2 of Table A2 in the appendix.

Figure 5. Margin Effects of Union Membership on Attitudes Toward Women's Employment over Time



Notes: This figure presents the marginal effects of union membership on attitudes toward women's employment over time. Yellow, blue, and red markers represent the results in the full sample, male sample, and female sample, respectively. Estimates are obtained from OLS regression of attitudes toward women's employment on two-way interaction between union membership and wave dummies, controlling for country effects, other covariates (including political orientation), and all lower-level terms from the two-way interaction. Bars indicate the 95% confidence interval constructed using robust standard errors. Models are estimated with the EVS weights.

Appendix

Table A1. Correlation Matrix of Variables Related to Gender Attitudes

	EVS 2-5		EVS-2	EVS 2-4			EVS-5		
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1. Attitudes toward women's employment (1 = less egalitarian, 3 = more egalitarian)	-	.336	.141	.178	.166	.165	.335	.313	.155
2. Women want a home and children (1 = agree strongly, 4 = disagree strongly)		-	.064	.231	.183	.185	.368	.341	.162
3. Women's movement (1 = disapprove, 4 = approve)			-	.096	.114	.114	n.a.	n.a.	n.a.
4. Women have to have children to be fulfilled (0 = necessary, 1 = not necessary)				-	.101	.101	n.a.	n.a.	n.a.
5. Women as a single parent (1 = disapprove, 3 = approve)					-	.974	n.a.	n.a.	n.a.
6. Job is the best way for women to be independent (1 = disagree strongly, 4 = agree strongly)						-	n.a.	n.a.	n.a.
7. Men make better political leaders (1 = agree strongly, 4 = disagree strongly)							-	.691	.145
8. Men make better business executives (1 = agree strongly, 4 = disagree strongly)								-	.129
9. Democracy: women have the same rights as men (0 = against, 10 = essential)									-

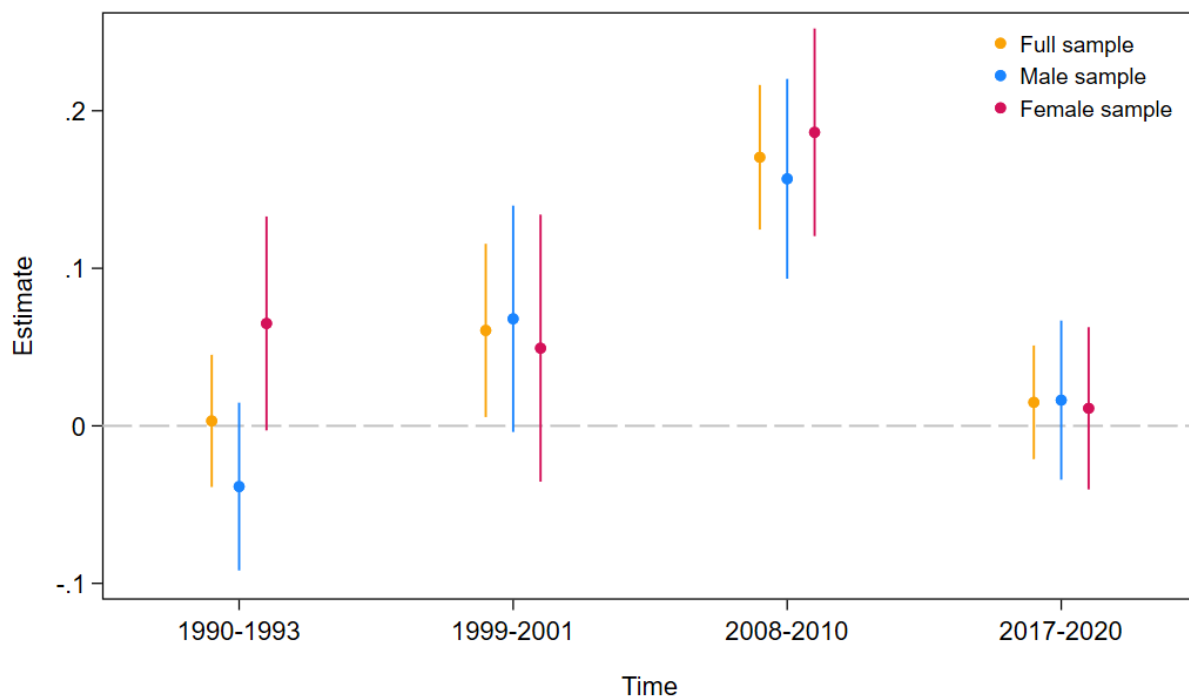
Notes: The table shows the pairwise correlations between all variables related to gender attitudes in the EVS. The top row indicates waves in which gender attitude variable are available. Some correlations cannot be calculated as variables are not always consistently measured across waves.

Table A2. OLS Regression of Attitudes toward Women's Employment on Two-Way Interaction
between Union Membership and Individual/Institutional Factors

	Individual Heterogeneity		Institutional Heterogeneity	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Union member	0.0869** (0.0380)	0.0756*** (0.0268)	-0.0563 (0.0385)	0.0624*** (0.0210)
Medium-skilled	0.0795*** (0.0188)	0.0775*** (0.0168)	0.0774*** (0.0168)	0.0774*** (0.0168)
High-skilled	0.1424*** (0.0200)	0.1120*** (0.0179)	0.1115*** (0.0179)	0.1108*** (0.0179)
Share of women in the occupation	0.0012*** (0.0003)	0.0014*** (0.0003)	0.0012*** (0.0003)	0.0012*** (0.0003)
Centralization of collective bargaining	0.1473*** (0.0198)	0.1478*** (0.0198)	0.1410*** (0.0203)	0.1477*** (0.0198)
Union density	-0.0045*** (0.0016)	-0.0043*** (0.0016)	-0.0043*** (0.0016)	-0.0042*** (0.0016)
Union member × Medium-skilled	-0.0191 (0.0393)			
Union member × High-skilled	-0.1409*** (0.0389)			
Union member × Share of women in the occupation		-0.0010** (0.0005)		
Union member × Centralization of collective bargaining			0.0317** (0.0153)	
Union member × Union density				-0.0008** (0.0004)
Full controls	×	×	×	×
Country effects	×	×	×	×
Wave effects	×	×	×	×
Observations	39877	39877	39877	39877
R-squared	0.202	0.201	0.201	0.201

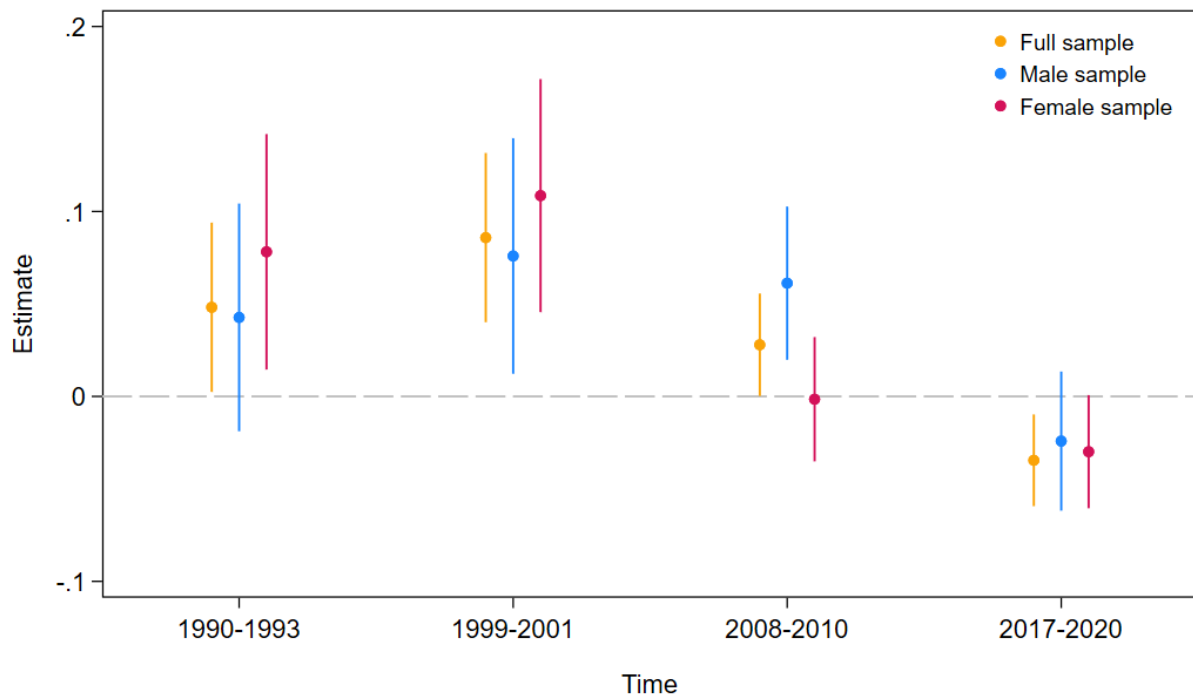
Notes: This table presents the OLS regression results of attitudes toward women's employment on two-way interaction between union membership and individual/institutional factors (skill levels, occupational gender composition, centralization of collective bargaining, and union density) in the full sample. Robust standard errors are reported in parentheses. *, **, *** indicate significance levels at 0.1, 0.05, and 0.01, respectively. Models are estimated using the EVS weights.

Figure A1. Margin Effects of Union Membership on Attitudes Toward Women's Roles over Time



Notes: This figure presents the marginal effects of union membership on attitudes toward women's roles over time, i.e. "A job is alright but what most women really want is a home and children" (from 1 = agree strongly to 4 = disagree strongly). Yellow, blue, and red markers represent the results in the full sample, male sample, and female sample, respectively. Estimates are obtained from OLS regression of attitudes toward women's roles on two-way interaction between union membership and wave dummies, controlling for country effects, other covariates (including political orientation), and all lower-level terms from the two-way interaction. Bars indicate the 95% confidence interval constructed using robust standard errors. Models are estimated with the EVS weights.

Figure A2. Margin Effects of Union Membership on Attitudes Toward Women's Employment over Time
(Employed Respondents Only)



Notes: This figure presents the marginal effects of union membership on attitudes toward women's employment over time, using a sample of employed respondents only. Yellow, blue, and red markers represent the results in the full sample, male sample, and female sample, respectively. Estimates are obtained from OLS regression of attitudes toward women's employment on two-way interaction between union membership and wave dummies, controlling for country effects, other covariates (including political orientation), and all lower-level terms from the two-way interaction. Bars indicate the 95% confidence interval constructed using robust standard errors. Models are estimated with the EVS weights.